WHAT IS A COLOSTOMY?

A colostomy is a surgically created opening of the colon – through the abdomen. The purpose of a colostomy is to allow stool to bypass a diseased or damaged part of the colon.
When a person has a colostomy, stool is no longer eliminated through the anus. Instead, stool is eliminated through the colostomy. A colostomy does not have a sphincter muscle, so a person who has a colostomy has no voluntary control over bowel movements. Instead, the person wears a disposable pouch to collect the stool. A colostomy may be temporary or permanent, depending on the medical reason for the surgery.
To construct a colostomy, the surgeon brings part of the colon through the abdominal wall. This new opening on the abdomen is called a stoma. The skin around the stoma is called the peristomal skin. Each person's stoma is unique. Chances are your stoma will look different from another person's stoma.
There are no nerve endings in the stoma, so the stoma is not painful. The stoma may also bleed easily especially if it is hit or rubbed. This type of minor temporary bleeding of the stoma is normal. [If the bleeding continues, or if the stool from the stoma is bloody, you should contact your doctor]. The stoma is always red and moist somewhat like the inside of a person's mouth.

ODOUR

Odour is a major concern for people who have a colostomy. Today, colostomy pouches are made with odour barrier film, so odour from the stool is contained inside the pouch. If the pouch is clean, and is applied properly, you should notice odour only when you are changing your pouch. If you notice odour at any other time, check the pouch seal for leakage.
You should empty your pouch when it is necessary and convenient, for many people that means twice per day.
Sometimes, certain foods can affect the odour of stool. If odour is a concern for you, you may want to avoid foods that increase odour. [See notes on diet].

GAS

The amount of gas that a person's system generates depends on the individual. If you had problems with excessive gas before your surgery, you will likely have the same problems after your surgery. Intestinal gas can sometimes be the result of swallowing air. Drinking carbonated beverages, smoking, chewing gum, and chewing with your mouth open can all increase the amount of air you swallow.
Sometimes gas can also be caused by the foods you eat. If gas is a problem for you, you may want to avoid certain gas forming foods, [see notes on diet].

DIET

Having a colostomy does not mean that you will have to be on a special diet. Remember, the actual digestion of food takes place almost entirely in the small intestine – not in the colon. Immediately after your surgery, your doctor may prescribe a special diet; however, after your recovery period, you should be able to go back to a normal diet. There are some foods that can cause odour or gas in your system. If that is a concern for you, you may want to eat those foods in moderation.

Remember always eat a balanced diet. Eat slowly and chew your food well. Add foods to your diet gradually, to see how those foods agree with your system.

Foods that may increase odour:

Asparagus, broccoli, brussel sprouts, cabbage, cauliflower, eggs, fish, garlic, onions and some spices.

Foods and beverages that may increase gas:

Beans, beer, broccoli, brussel sprouts, cabbage, carbonated beverages, cauliflower, corn, cucumbers, mushrooms, peas, spinach.

DIARRHOEA

Diarrhoea can be caused by an illness, or by a variety of reasons. With a colostomy, you can still get diarrhoea.

At first your colostomy may produce stools several times daily; however after a few months you will notice that your colostomy will start emptying about twice to three times daily. You will be able to control colostomy function more easily.

If you get diarrhoea, there are some foods you can eat that will help to thicken your stools. Avoid foods and beverages that may cause loose stools.

Foods and beverages that may thicken your stools;

Applesauce, bananas, cheese, marshmallows, boiled milk, noodles, rice, toast and yogurt.

Foods and beverages that may cause loose stools;

Beer or other alcohol, broccoli, grape and prune juice, green beans, spicy foods, fresh fruits except banana and spinach.

Remember that if symptoms of diarrhoea persist to seek medical attention.

MEDICATION

Any medication you take will work just as effectively as before. Some medication may change the colour and odour of your stools.

BATHING OR SHOWERING

With a colostomy, you can shower or bathe just as you did before, Soap and water will not flow into your stoma or hurt your stoma in any way. You may choose to shower or bathe with your pouch on or off – the choice is yours. Because soap residue can sometimes interfere with how well the skin barrier or adhesive sticks to your skin, avoid soap that leaves a residue on your skin.

SKIN CARE

It is very important for the skin around the stoma to remain healthy and free of irritation. The peristomal skin should look just like the skin elsewhere on your abdomen. To prevent skin irritation you must have a skin barrier and wafer and pouch that fits properly. Each time you remove your skin barrier and wafer, look carefully at the peristomal skin for any signs of irritation. If the problem persists contact your stoma care nurse.

CLOTHING

After colostomy surgery, many people worry that the pouch will be visible under their clothing. Some people think they won't be able to wear 'normal' clothes, or that they will have to wear clothes that are

too big for them. The fact is, you should be able to wear the same type of clothes you wore before your surgery. Also today's pouches are so thin and fit so close to the body, chances are no one will know you are wearing a pouch – unless you tell them.

EXERCISE AND SPORTS

A colostomy should not prevent you from exercising or from being physically active. Other than extremely rough contact sports and very heavy lifting, you should be able to enjoy the same type of physical activities you enjoyed before your surgery.

RETURNING TO WORK AND TRAVELLING

As with any surgery, you will need to allow some recovery time. Recovery from this type of surgery can take from six to eight weeks. You should check with your doctor before returning to work.
After your recovery, you should be able to return to work, or travel just about anywhere. Your colostomy should not limit you.

Important tips;
When you go out always have a wafer and pouch with you.
Fasten seat belt above or below your stoma,
Never leave your ostomy items in a hot car – the adhesive can melt.
When travelling by air, keep you ostomy products with you in your hand luggage not in your checked luggage.

SEX AND PERSONAL RELATIONSHIPS

Because colostomy surgery is a body altering procedure, many people worry about sex and intimacy and about acceptance by their spouse or loved one. For people who are dating a big concern is how to tell someone about their colostomy.
It is important to remember that supportive personal relationships can be major sources of healing after any type of surgery. It is also important to let your partner know that sexual activity will not hurt you or your stoma.
Colostomy surgery affects both partners in a relationship, and it is something to which both partners must adjust - each in his or her own way. The key, of course, is understanding and communication.

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